

MyTradeBook.com

The web site is supposed to be a fusion of a networking and a trading site. 40 per cent of its registered users are from India, and gaining access to potential global customers

LinkedIn Traffic

With the down turn in the economy, the business networking web site's traffic has shown a sharp increase. ComScore reported the rise to be an increase of 22 per cent

Business networking

There's more to networking than just catching up with old and long lost school friends or wasting time doing nothing constructive. And this is where business networking comes in. In addition to posting your profiles on job portals, signing up with business or professional networking sites will boost the probability of connecting with strategic people and could land you a job. Not just that, professional networking also increases your circle of professional contacts, thereby assisting you in decision making, come an emergency.

Although the idea is more or less the same as social networking, the underlying sentiments are more serious and need greater privacy and integrity. Hence, filtering out spammers becomes all the more important. When you're out there looking out for something serious, the last thing you want is to be linked to by unknown people for no reason.

Essentially, the first thing you look for in a professional networking site is privacy, credibility, integrity and appropriate users to interact with. These will certainly differ from user to user, but we can assess the sites according to their functionality and operability. We looked into the options we had and came across several web sites that claimed to be the one answer to your business networking needs.

The sites that we closed in on in our

final comparison were **SiliconIndia.com** and **LinkedIn.com**, in addition to a few other web sites that fell below our expectations. There is a significant difference between **SiliconIndia.com** and **LinkedIn.com**, and so there is a clear winner here. LinkedIn has a very intuitive interface that takes you straight to where you need to go, with a vast storehouse of users. The reason we even included SiliconIndia is that, from an Indian perspective, **SiliconIndia.com** seems

to be the only web site that has a user base of a significant size. At the last count, it had approximately 3.2 million registered users, more importantly from the Indian subcontinent.

So, for the contender of our professional networking award, **SiliconIndia.com** does well as our runner up. Coming to our winner, **LinkedIn.com** takes privacy very seriously. Firstly, it encourages you to add contacts only if you know them. LinkedIn prompts you to mention how you know the contact or supply their email address. Further, it needs the approval of the other person (referred to as a connection in LinkedIn) for the connection to be complete. The best part is that, if over a period of time several people say they don't know you, LinkedIn automatically keeps tabs on you and you will not be able to add contacts directly until you commit not to add contacts without knowing them. As far as the number of registered users go, there are 45 million users on **LinkedIn.com**.

The likelihood that you will meet more people from your professional circle is higher on LinkedIn than any other professional networking site. Also, going by the number of prominent users on LinkedIn, the site's credibility is indisputable. Barack Obama, Sarah Palin, Bill Gates and Steve Jobs are just some of the personalities you will find on **LinkedIn.com**.

LinkedIn has a large number of groups and associations. If you are a technologist and plan to launch your venture, you will find a vast pool of venture capitalists registered with LinkedIn. Even college students and professionals across sectors are active here.

LinkedIn.com also has a very useful tool called LinkedIn Answers that lets you ask any question that you may have relevant to your profession or business and the vast pool of LinkedIn users will answer it for you. **d**

Networking Feature Picks

brijj.com - A business networking web site launched by the people behind naukri.com. It's an extension of their job search service, and the network has received quite a sizable amount of registrations since its launch. An interesting feature is the way interaction takes place within groups. Members can share files such as documents and presentations in the group apart from the possibility of having discussions on topics. Events are also organised within each group.

Waprr.com - A newer kid on the block; this web site was started by young entrepreneurs from Hyderabad. We found the site to be extremely customisable. It has strong privacy features and an easy navigation scheme. Since the site is new, understandably it has fewer members. The web site is not only a professional network but also a tool for companies to attract talent. What we found strange though was the lack of straight forward groups or communities.

toostep.com - This web site is based on a slightly different philosophy. Rather than just simple networking, the web site puts a lot of stress on the sharing of knowledge and open collaboration to generate innovative ideas. The community has a reward system in the form of badges and points for contributors. The three ways to participate on the web site are through "Debate", "Ideate", "Insight" and "Q&A" modules. Ideate allows you to ask for ideas from the community, through Insight you can publish articles, and Q&A lets you ask and answer questions.

peerpower.com - Peer power is an exclusive, invitation only, network launched by the Times of India group. The site seems to be too niche in its current form. It allows you to register only with your corporate email id but only after you get an invitation. An interesting feature we found on the site was the make your own newspaper feature. It allows you to use RSS feeds to aggregate news from different sources. The feeds are placed in an attractive newspaper format. You can then publish this newspaper and others on the network can subscribe to it.